Fact, Observation or Open Question? A One-Page Sheet for Sorting What You Hear About Dad

Eighteen words and categories in one plain line each, and what to write down for each.

“The doctor thinks.” “Your aunt says.” “I'm pretty sure.” In a busy week they all land in the same pile of notes. This sheet gives each kind of note a label, and names the parts of a care situation worth writing down.

The labels in the first two groups are the Family Care Roadmap's own. Where a word comes from a public source, the source is marked. None of it is for judging how Dad is doing.

Labels for what you hear

Confirmed fact

Something you've seen in writing or checked with the person who would know: a time on an appointment card, a name on a hospital paper.

WRITE DOWN The fact, where you saw it or who confirmed it, and the date.

Family observation

Something a family member saw or heard first-hand. It's true to what that person saw, and it may not be the whole story.

WRITE DOWN What was seen, by whom, and on what day. Leave out what you think it means.

Second-hand report

Something one person tells you another person said: “the nurse told your sister.”

WRITE DOWN Who told you, who they heard it from, and “to confirm” beside it.

Unanswered question

Something nobody in the family can answer yet.

WRITE DOWN The question, and who might be able to answer it.

Not yet known

The label for a gap. It goes where a guess would otherwise go.

WRITE DOWN Those three words, in the space you'd have filled with a guess.

The situation

Reason for seeking help

The event or change that started this: a fall, a hospital stay, a call from a neighbor.

WRITE DOWN What happened, the day, and who was there.

Current arrangement

Where Dad lives and who helps him, as things stand today.

WRITE DOWN Where he is living, who lives with him, and who comes in.

Proposed change

Something a person has suggested should be different. It stays a proposal until the family decides.

WRITE DOWN The suggestion, who made it, and when.

Typical day

One ordinary day described from morning to overnight, in place of a label like “managing fine.”

WRITE DOWN Morning, daytime, evening and overnight: who is there, and what they do.

Upcoming decision

A choice the family has been told it will need to make.

WRITE DOWN The decision in one sentence, who raised it, and any date they gave.

Next conversation

The next time the situation will be talked through, within the family or with a professional.

WRITE DOWN When it is, who will be in it, and who is making sure it happens.

The people

Caregiver

Anyone who helps care for an older person or a person with a disability who lives at home, as the federal long-term care glossary defines it. Some are family members or friends; others are paid professionals. [1] [2]

WRITE DOWN Everyone who fits, and what each one does.

Primary caregiver

The person who takes on most of the everyday caregiving responsibilities, as the National Institute on Aging describes the role. [3]

WRITE DOWN Who that is right now, and what they say when you ask which parts are becoming difficult.

Family contact (point person)

The one person who takes the calls and passes on the news. AARP's planning guide calls this a point person: someone who keeps the process moving and makes sure people understand what's been decided. [4]

WRITE DOWN A name and number for now, and a backup for when that person can't be reached.

Discharge planner

If Dad is in the hospital, your point person there for planning what follows the stay. It may be a dedicated discharge planning manager, a social worker, a nurse or another hospital representative. [5]

WRITE DOWN Their name, and a phone number or email address.

Who does what

The work of Dad's care, task by task, as it really gets done. The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests caregivers list all the things they do, partly for family members who may not be aware of their efforts. [6]

WRITE DOWN Each task, the name of who does it, and whether you've confirmed it with them.

Paper

Care plan

The CDC's name for a form summarizing a person's health conditions, specific care needs and current treatments. Your family's page of notes is a different thing. [7]

WRITE DOWN Whether Dad has one, who wrote it, and where a copy is.

Consent form

The form most doctors' offices and hospitals have for naming who may receive a person's private medical information. It is sometimes called a HIPAA release. [8]

WRITE DOWN Which offices have one with your name on it, and which you still need to ask.

What this sheet doesn't do

It labels and defines. It doesn't say which notes matter most, what any of them means for Dad, or what your family should decide. That's for the people who assess him.

Ready for the next step?

You can label what you hear about Dad, and you know what to write beside it. The care interview gives those notes somewhere to go: it walks you through his situation one area at a time and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Glossary
2. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine), Caregivers
3. National Institute on Aging (NIH), Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities
4. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
5. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers
6. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving 101: On Being a Caregiver
7. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Steps for Creating and Maintaining a Care Plan
8. National Institute on Aging (NIH), Taking Someone to a Doctor’s Appointment: Tips for Caregivers